WEEK 11 · LECTURE L3 · UNIT IV

Writing for a Board: The Pyramid Principle

How senior readers read, how to structure an argument they can act on, and the common failures of HR memos.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

1. Structure a Board memo with Minto’s pyramid principle: answer first, then reasons, then evidence.
2. Use SCQA to frame the opening paragraph.
3. State what a Board needs from an HR memo: one ask, three reasons, honest risks, a report back and an exit point.
4. Diagnose and fix the common failures of HR memos, including misleading figures.

ONE SOURCE

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcomes: CLO 4 and CLO 5.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Commit to an answer first

A Board member reads only the first paragraph of an HR memo. What should that paragraph contain?

A

The background and history of the problem

B

The recommendation and the decision asked for, with amount and date

C

A summary of the methods used

D

Thanks to the team

EXAM LENS

The answer is B.

MINTO (1987; 2009)

The pyramid principle

The answer

One recommendation, one ask, with amount and date.

Three reasons

Each a summary of the evidence beneath it.

Evidence

For each reason, the figures and facts that support it.

EXAM LENS

Each level summarizes the level below it; the reader can stop at any level and still have the point. Readers at the top of an organization read the first paragraph and decide whether to read further.

SCQA

Opening a memo

Situation

What the Board already knows and accepts.

Complication

What has changed or gone wrong.

Question

What that raises for the Board.

Answer

Your recommendation; in a memo, move it to the top.

EXAM LENS

For a Board, lead with the answer and keep SCQA as the logic of the first paragraph.

WHAT A BOARD NEEDS FROM AN HR MEMO

Four parts

One clear ask

Amount, date and the decision required.

Three reasons

Each with one figure at company scale, not a sample count.

Honest risks

What could go wrong, and the counter measure that would reveal it.

A report back

What HR will report, when, and when the Board can stop the program.

COURSE FRAMING

A Board can say yes to a decision, not to a list of activities.

COMMON FAILURES, AND THEIR FIXES

Most weak memos fail on structure, not content

Failure	Fix
Ask buried on page two	Move it to the first paragraph
Sample counts quoted as company figures	State the population and scale correctly
A list of projects	State the decision and the operating model
Unsupported certainty	Give ranges and the main uncertainty
No exit point	Name the measure and the date at which the Board can stop
Jargon	Write for an intelligent reader outside HR

A WEAK OPENING AND A STRONG ONE

Can it be approved, questioned or rejected in one reading?

Weak

“Over the last three years HR has undertaken several initiatives in digital transformation. Our team has worked hard on various projects, and we would like to share progress and seek the Board’s guidance on next steps.” It names no decision, amount or date.

Strong

“We ask the Board to approve ₹4 crore over 18 months to move all 9,000 staff onto one HR record and mobile self service. Three reasons: [one line each]. We will report at month 6, and recommend stopping if active use is below 50%.”

EXAM LENS

The strong opening leads with the decision, the money, the scope and the review point.

HONEST FIGURES IN A MEMO

Bring Week 8 into the memo

Points or percent

Say which: 20% to 15% is 5 points, a 25% relative fall.

Base and scale

Give the base for every rise; scale a sample to the population and say so.

Counter measure

Pair the headline with the number that would reveal gaming.

Charts

Zero baselines for bars, full periods, uncertainty for small groups (Knaflic, 2015).

APPLY

Rewrite a memo for a Board

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Noida software firm’s HR head drafts a six page memo on an AI based learning platform. Page one describes the firm’s learning history; page four mentions a cost of ₹2.4 crore; nowhere does it say what the Board must decide. One chart shows a 25% rise in course completions without the base.

Work it through

1. Write the first paragraph using the pyramid principle.
2. Which SCQA element is missing?
3. Fix the chart claim, using Week 8.
4. Add an exit point and a counter measure.

COMMON CONFUSIONS

Tempting readings, and better ones

A tempting reading	A better reading
Good memos build up to the conclusion	Senior readers need the answer first
More detail shows rigor	Detail belongs lower in the pyramid; the top must be short
A memo reports progress	A Board memo asks for a decision
Certainty persuades	Ranges and an exit point earn trust

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

Write the opening paragraph and outline of a Board memo asking an Indian bank to fund an HR analytics capability. Explain how your structure applies the pyramid principle and SCQA, and how you avoid misleading the Board. **20 marks**

A strong answer: leads with one ask, amount and date; organizes three reasons with evidence; uses SCQA for the first paragraph; includes honest risks, a counter measure and an exit point.

Explain the pyramid principle and why it suits Board readers. **10 marks**

A strong answer: answer first, reasons, evidence; each level summarizes the one below; senior readers decide on the first paragraph.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Four things to remember

1. **Answer first.**
   One ask, amount and date in the first paragraph.

2. **Three reasons, each with evidence at company scale.**
   Never a sample count as a company figure.

3. **Honest risks and a counter measure.**
   Ranges, not false certainty.

4. **Give the Board an exit point.**
   A measure and a date at which it can stop.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this week

- Sample Board memos, strong and weak examples, annotated.
- Westerman et al. (2014), leadership and strategy chapters.

NEXT WEEK

- Week 12: pod presentations and a comprehensive review of the core readings.

> **NOTE**
> The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

- Knaflic, C. N. (2015). *Storytelling with data*. Wiley.
- Minto, B. (1987). *The pyramid principle: Logic in writing and thinking*. Minto International; (2009 edition). Pearson Education.